17

Babur in Tashkent
(July of AD 1502–June AD of 1503)

His Poverty

The great Khān's new move was useless and unprofitable in Babur's opinion. He was not on a quest to take up a fort or beat any enemy. He was simply entering and leaving the regions. Babur's stay did not seem like a good experience for him either. During his stay in Tashkent, Babur was not only impoverished but also humiliation had become a part of his daily life. The Tīmūrid prince did not own or control any country and it seemed as if despair was there to stay. Most of his retainers had dispersed and those left in small numbers were unable to move about with Babur because of their own insolvency.

The desperation of Babur to get country, lordship and the house was very much evident. When he went to Khān Dada's Gate, only a man or two accompanied him. He would often walk into Shāh Begum's house, bareheaded and barefoot as if it was his own.

This uncertainty and want of house had sent him into a state of loathing. He has written in the *Baburnama*, 'It would be better to take my head and go off than live in such misery; better to go as far as my feet can carry me than be seen of men in such poverty and humiliation.'

Then, Babur decided to move to China. It had always been his wish, perhaps since he was a child, to visit China. But, the royal duties and attachments had always kept this dream at bay. Now that sovereignty itself was gone and his mother seemed settled with her stepmother and younger brother, Babur thought it was an apt time to visit China. Babur sent out Khwāja Abū'l-makāram as his representative to Shāh Begum and the Khān. He conveyed that 'now such a foe as Shaybāni Khān had made his appearance, Moghūl and Turk alike must guard against him; that thought